give the appearance of supporting separatist movements fighting for self-determination and secession given its own positions in Tibet and toward the indigenous Uighur population in the Xinjiang province. The Chinese government called for a political settlement, while several articles in the Chinese press blamed the West for supporting regime change in Ukraine.

All the BRICS refused to participate in the sanctions regime, just as they rebuffed unilateral sanctions against Iran that were not approved by the United Nations. Putin was welcomed collegially at the 6th BRICS Summit in Fortaleza, Brazil, in July 2014 and at the 8th BRICS Summit in Goa, India, in October 2016, and he also hosted the 7th BRICS Summit in July 2015 in Ufa, Russia, with all the BRICS heads of state in attendance. In Ufa, Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi insisted, "Unilateral sanctions are hurting the global economy. So it is very essential that BRICS economies deepen their cooperation." The summit declarations from 2014 through 2016 consistently emphasized BRICS opposition to unilateral economic sanctions as a violation of international law.[90]

President Xi Jinping also paved the way for economic deals with Russia despite the reticence of Chinese commercial banks to ignore sanctions. Russian-Chinese trade rebounded in the first three quarters of 2016, after dropping by almost 30 percent in 2015 following the collapse in oil prices. The volume of Russian oil exports actually increased, making Russia the largest or second-largest supplier of crude to China (roughly equivalent to Saudi Arabia). Moreover, although previously reticent to permit equity positions above 25 percent in strategic sectors such as oil and gas, the Kremlin felt compelled to ease such restrictions given the impact of the sanctions, the drop in the oil price, and Rosneft's financial constraints. Thus, China's National Petroleum Corporation (CNPC). and China's Silk Road Fund combined acquired a 30 percent stake in Russia's Yamal Liquefied Natural Gas (LNG) project as two Chinese banks extended $12 billion in credit lines. Likewise, a consortium of Indian firms acquired a 26 percent stake in Russian oil company Vankorneft from Rosneft. Russian arms sales of advanced weapons, such as the S-400 surface-to-air missile and Su-35 fighters to China and India, also boomed. China became Russia's largest source of foreign capital in 2015 (excluding Russian capital reimported from Cyprus).[91] These were strong signals that Washington could not impose the diplomatic isolation of a major power.

As discussed in Chapter 4, it is unclear whether the sanctions and threats to escalate them deterred more aggressive Russian action in Ukraine than in fact